



Triumphant smile: Vidarbha exorcised its 2023-24 demons in style, clinching a thrilling first-innings lead before grinding Kerala down for nearly five sessions to secure its third Ranji Trophy title. NIRMAL HARINDRAN

But, when the Kerala score read 326 for six — another 54 away from the first-innings lead — Baby, batting on 98 in his 100th First-Class game, played a shot he will never want to watch the highlight of. The man who had hardly played anything risky until that moment went for a slog sweep against Parth Rekhade to find the only man in the deep on the leg side, Karun Nair.

Not since the England captain Mike Gatting reverse-swept his Australian counterpart Allan Border in the 1987 World Cup final have many men played such a costly shot at such a crucial juncture. Naturally, Baby was asked about it after the match.

“Nobody plays a shot to get out, and that shot wasn’t actually on my mind at all,” he explained. “Yes, maybe it was a brain-fade moment.”

That wasn’t the only regret for Kerala in the final. There was the dropped catch of Karun in Vidarbha’s

second innings.

Karun was batting on 31, and his team was on 55 for two when Akshay Chandran dropped him at slip off Eden Apple Tom, the 19-year-old seamer who impressed everyone on his return to First-Class cricket after a three-year break.

Karun went on to bat Kerala out of the final, making his fourth hundred in the Ranji Trophy this season. It was also his ninth century for Vidarbha, having made five in the Vijay Hazare Trophy, in which his numbers would have made even Don Bradman envious. After completing his hundred, he signalled the number nine through his hands. There was speculation if it was meant for the national selectors at the venue. Though Karun said he was addressing the support staff at the dressing room, he added with a mischievous smile, “You can take it whichever way you want.”

Last season, Karun was more

Top five run-getters (2025)



Yash Rathod (Vidarbha)

960 runs in 10 matches (HS: 151, Avg: 53.33)

Shubham Sharma (Madhya Pradesh)

943 runs in 7 matches (HS: 240, Avg: 104.77)

Tanmay Agarwal (Hyderabad)

934 runs in 7 matches (HS: 177, Avg: 77.83)

Karun Nair (Vidarbha)

863 runs in 9 matches (HS: 135, Avg: 53.93)

Danish Malewar (Vidarbha)

783 runs in 9 matches (HS: 153, Avg: 52.20)